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POLITICS OF EUROPEAN INTEGRATION: CLASSROOM EXERCISE

The Brexit Negotiation

A 75-minute two-round negotiation simulation of the Article 50 withdrawal talks, with a public-opinion “tweet” media mechanic.

Topic tags: Brexit · Article 50 · the Irish border and backstop · single market and customs union · public opinion and social media

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Abstract

This simulation drops students into the Brexit withdrawal negotiations shortly after the United Kingdom triggered Article 50. Students embody one of four actors: the UK Government, the Democratic Unionist Party (DUP), the Irish Government, or the European Commission. Working from a position brief, they negotiate three contentious files: the Irish border and the backstop, the future trade relationship, and security cooperation. The negotiation runs in two rounds. In Round 1 the two aligned actors on each side (UK plus DUP; Commission plus Ireland) bargain internally to agree a common line. In Round 2 each side consolidates into a single delegation with a nominated spokesperson, and the two delegations negotiate across the table. The distinctive feature is a public-opinion layer: between and after the rounds, each side composes a short public “tweet” declaring its aims and, later, reporting its results, forcing students to reconcile private bargaining with public messaging. The exercise is designed to make visible how internal cohesion, veto threats, red lines and media pressure shaped a real, high-stakes negotiation.

Learning outcomes

By the end of this exercise students will be able to:

- Explain the core disputes of the Brexit withdrawal negotiations: the Irish border and the backstop, the trade-off between leaving the single market and customs union and avoiding a hard border, and the future of security cooperation.
- Analyse how a negotiating side’s internal cohesion (here, the UK-DUP and Commission-Ireland relationships) constrains what it can offer at the external table.
- Assess the role of public opinion and social media as a constraint on negotiators, distinguishing what is sayable in public from what is bargainable in private.
- Evaluate the negotiated outcome they reach against the real 2018 Withdrawal Agreement, and explain the divergence.

At a glance

Duration	75 minutes (55 minutes of simulation including tweets, plus 20 minutes debrief)
Class size	12–32 students in four role groups; scales to smaller and larger classes (see Adaptation notes)
Room setup	One room, moveable seating; two clusters for Round 1 (a “UK side” and an “EU side”), brought together for Round 2; projector for the slides and the tweet board
Materials needed	The four role briefs (Appendix B); the projected slide deck with the scenario, round structure and timers; a shared “tweet board” (a projected slide, whiteboard, or shared document) to capture the public messages; a facilitator outcome-scoring sheet (Appendix A)
Instructor prep time	45–60 minutes (allocate roles, print or share briefs, set up the tweet board and timers)
Student prep time	20–30 minutes reading their brief and the scenario in advance

Pre-class preparation

For the instructor

- Divide the class into four role groups: **UK Government**, **DUP**, **Irish Government**, and **European Commission**. Aim for 3–6 students per group. If numbers are uneven, weight the two “lead” roles (UK Government and European Commission) more heavily, since they carry the negotiation in Round 2; keep the DUP and Ireland groups smaller.
- The two sides are fixed: the **UK side** is the UK Government plus the DUP; the **EU side** is the European Commission plus Ireland. Seat the two allies together so they can caucus in Round 1.
- Distribute the relevant role brief (Appendix B) to each group at least a day before class. Ask students to read the scenario framing and their own brief, and to note their red lines and their room for compromise on each of the three files.
- Set up a **tweet board**: a projected slide, a section of whiteboard, or a shared document with a column per side. This is where the public messages will be posted and read aloud. Decide in advance whether students will type into a shared document, write on the board, or hand you a slip to read out. Do not use a live third-party social platform; a shared document or the board is enough.
- Have the outcome-scoring sheet (Appendix A) ready so you can adjudicate the deal at the end (see the session plan and Appendix A for the rule).
- Set a visible countdown timer for each timed phase.

For students

- Read your role brief and the scenario. Come ready to argue your assigned position and to set aside your own views on Brexit.
- Identify, for each of the three files (border, trade, security), what you must secure, where you can move, and which other actor is your ally or your obstacle.

Session plan

The simulation runs to 55 minutes of activity plus a 20-minute debrief, for a 75-minute total. The scenario: Article 50 has been triggered. A withdrawal agreement must be reached on three files, the Irish border and backstop, trade, and security, against a deadline and under public scrutiny. The tweet mechanic runs throughout and should not be skipped: it is the point of difference of this exercise.

Time	Phase	What happens
0:00–0:07	Introduction	Set the scene using the slides. Confirm the four roles, the two sides, and the three files. Explain the two-round structure, the tweet mechanic, and how you will adjudicate the outcome (Appendix A).
0:07–0:12	Familiarisation	Groups reread their brief and agree an opening line on each of the three files with their ally.
0:12–0:22	Round 1 (internal caucus)	Each side negotiates <i>within itself</i> : UK Government with DUP, Commission with Ireland. The goal is a single agreed position on border, trade and security to take to the external table. The junior partner (DUP, Ireland) presses its priorities; the lead actor manages them. (10 minutes.)
0:22–0:27	Tweet 1 (aims)	Each side composes one short public tweet (under 280 characters) declaring what it will fight for. Post it to the tweet board and read it aloud. This locks in a public position the side must later answer for.
0:27–0:30	Consolidation	Each side merges into a single delegation and nominates one spokesperson (others may still pass notes and advise).
0:30–0:45	Round 2 (across the table)	The UK delegation and the EU delegation negotiate face to face on the three files, working toward a deal. The spokesperson leads; the facilitator keeps time and notes what is agreed. (15 minutes.)
0:45–0:50	Tweet 2 (results)	Each side composes a second tweet reporting how the negotiation went and what it secured. Post and read aloud. Compare each side's two tweets:

Time	Phase	What happens
		did the public promise survive contact with the table?
0:50–0:55	Adjudication	The facilitator scores the outcome against the scoring sheet (Appendix A) and announces whether a deal was reached, on what terms, and how it compares to the real 2018 Withdrawal Agreement.
0:55–1:15	Debrief	Run the debrief questions below (20 minutes).

How the deal is adjudicated. The original exercise left the outcome undefined; use this rule. A file is “agreed” only if both delegations accept the same wording. Score the final deal on the scoring sheet in Appendix A: award points per file for reaching agreement and, separately, for how far each side protected its red lines. A withdrawal agreement is reached only if all three files are agreed *and* neither side has crossed a stated red line (for the UK, no regulatory border in the Irish Sea that the House of Commons and DUP would reject; for the EU, the integrity of the single market and a backstop guarantee against a hard border). If a red line is crossed, announce a “no deal”, which is itself a legitimate and instructive outcome. Do not steer the room toward the historical result; adjudicate what they actually agreed.

Debrief and reflection

Allow 20 minutes. The debrief is where the learning lands, so protect the time. Group the questions as follows.

Internal cohesion (the two sides look inward). Surfaces how the junior partner constrained the lead.

- UK side: how much did the DUP’s red lines limit what the UK could offer on the border? Did the confidence-and-supply leverage bite?
- EU side: how far did Ireland shape the Commission’s line? Did “one voice” hold, or did Ireland pull the Commission further than it wanted to go?
- For both: did your Round 1 caucus make your Round 2 position stronger or more rigid?

The public-opinion mechanic (the tweets). Surfaces the gap between public messaging and private bargaining.

- Compare your side’s two tweets. Did you deliver what you promised, or did you have to spin a compromise?
- Did the knowledge that you would tweet publicly change what you were willing to concede at the table?
- Whose citizens would be satisfied with the deal you reached? Whose would feel betrayed?

- In the real negotiations, how did media and public pressure constrain the negotiators? Did your experience mirror that?

Comparison with the real negotiations. Surfaces the substance and the counterfactual.

- What deal did you reach on each file? Where did it match, and where did it diverge from, the real 2018 Withdrawal Agreement and the backstop?
- Which file was hardest to agree, and why? Was the border always the sticking point, as it was in reality?
- If you reached “no deal”, what would have had to change for a deal to be possible?
- Knowing how Brexit unfolded, what did the simulation get right about the underlying dynamics, and what did it necessarily simplify?

Assessment suggestions

The exercise works well ungraded, but if assessment is wanted, keep it light:

- A short individual reflection (300–500 words) answering two or three debrief questions, especially on the tension between public messaging and private compromise.
- A participation mark for staying in role and engaging in both rounds.
- Submit the two tweets per side as a small deliverable, with a one-paragraph note explaining the gap (if any) between the promise and the result.

Adaptation notes

- **Scaling down.** With as few as eight students, run two per role group and shorten each round by 2–3 minutes. With four students, collapse to one negotiator per role and run Round 1 as a quick paired conversation.
- **Scaling up.** With more than 32, either add observer-journalists who write the tweets and grade each side’s consistency, or run two parallel tables and compare the two outcomes in the debrief.
- **Difficulty.** To sharpen the conflict, harden the briefs (for example, make the DUP refuse any time-limited backstop, or make the Commission insist the backstop apply to Northern Ireland only). To ease it, allow a time-limited backstop as a pre-cleared landing zone.
- **The media mechanic.** The tweet step is the distinctive element; keep it. Vary it by allowing each side one “reply” tweet reacting to the other side’s aims tweet, or by appointing a student “press” role to score how well each tweet matches what was actually agreed.
- **Online delivery.** Put each side in its own breakout room for Round 1, bring both into the main room for Round 2, and use a shared document or a chat channel as the tweet board. Read tweets aloud on camera.
- **Different topic.** The two-round structure (internal caucus, then external table) plus the public-tweet layer transfers to any negotiation where each side is a coalition answerable to a public: EU enlargement talks, climate negotiations, or a coalition-government formation.

Appendix A: Instructor materials

A1. Facilitator script (short)

Opening (to the whole room). “Article 50 has been triggered. The United Kingdom is leaving the European Union, and a withdrawal agreement must be negotiated. You are one of four actors: the UK Government, the DUP, the Irish Government, or the European Commission. Three files are on the table: the Irish border and the backstop, trade, and security. You will negotiate in two rounds. First you agree a line with your ally; then the two sides meet across the table. Throughout, you will speak to your public by composing tweets, because in Brexit the media and public opinion were never far from the room. At the end I will decide whether you have a deal.”

Before Round 1. “Caucus with your ally. The UK Government works with the DUP; the Commission works with Ireland. Agree one position on each of the three files. You have ten minutes.”

Before each tweet. “Compose one tweet, under 280 characters, and post it to the board. I will read them out.”

Before Round 2. “Merge into one delegation per side and nominate a spokesperson. You have fifteen minutes to reach a deal.”

At adjudication. Use the scoring sheet (A2) and announce the result plainly: which files were agreed, whether any red line was crossed, and therefore whether there is a withdrawal agreement or a no deal.

A2. Outcome scoring sheet (facilitator)

Fill this in during Round 2 and at adjudication. A file is “agreed” only when both delegations accept the same wording.

File	Agreed? (Y/N)	UK red line held?	EU red line held?	Notes on the terms
Irish border and backstop		(no NI-only Irish Sea border the DUP would reject)	(backstop guarantees no hard border; single-market integrity)	
Trade (single market / customs union)		(UK leaves single market and customs union)	(level playing field; EU standards upheld)	
Security cooperation		(maintain PSNI–Garda cooperation)	(data-sharing and law-enforcement continuity)	

Verdict. A withdrawal agreement is reached only if all three files are agreed and no red line was crossed. Otherwise, declare “no deal”. Note which side moved most and where the deal sits relative to the real 2018 Withdrawal Agreement (which contained a UK-wide customs backstop with extra alignment for Northern Ireland).

A3. Model outcome (for the facilitator's orientation only)

The real 2018 Withdrawal Agreement settled the border with a backstop: the whole UK would remain in a single customs territory with the EU, with Northern Ireland additionally aligned to some single-market rules, avoiding a hard land border but implying some checks in the Irish Sea. The DUP rejected it; the Commons rejected it three times. A plausible classroom deal will approximate this and expose the same fault line: the UK-DUP insistence on no Irish Sea border versus the EU-Ireland insistence on no land border. Reaching a “no deal” in class is realistic and worth discussing, not a failure of the exercise.

A4. Further reading

- Springford, J. (2018) ‘Theresa May’s Irish Trilemma’. Centre for European Reform.
<https://www.cer.eu/insights/theresa-mays-irish-trilemma>. A clear statement of the trade-off at the heart of the exercise.
- House of Commons Library (2019) ‘The Irish backstop’. Briefing paper CBP-8397.
<https://commonslibrary.parliament.uk/research-briefings/cbp-8397/>. Neutral explainer of the backstop.
- Carswell, S. (2019) ‘Brexit explained: why does the Border matter and what is the backstop?’, *The Irish Times*, 29 April. <https://www.irishtimes.com/news/politics/brexit-explained-why-does-the-border-matter-and-what-is-the-backstop-1.3661518>.
- European Council, ‘The EU’s response to Brexit’. <https://www.consilium.europa.eu>. On the EU27 negotiating structure and the Barnier taskforce.

Appendix B: Student handouts and role briefs

Each brief gives a group its position and red lines on the three files, plus a short options menu and its sources. Positions may be sharpened for the exercise. Read the scenario, then your own brief.

Scenario (all roles). Article 50 has been triggered. The United Kingdom is leaving the European Union and a withdrawal agreement must be negotiated on three files: the Irish border and the backstop, the future trade relationship, and security cooperation. You represent one actor. In Round 1 you agree a common line with your ally (the UK Government with the DUP; the European Commission with Ireland). In Round 2 your side merges into one delegation and negotiates across the table with the other side. Between and after the rounds, you speak to your public by composing tweets.

UK Government

Who you are. You represent the British government. “Brexit means Brexit.” The Prime Minister, Theresa May, has warned that if a good deal cannot be reached, the UK is prepared to leave without one. Your position is difficult: the numbers in the House of Commons are tight and you depend on the DUP’s support, so you cannot agree anything the DUP will reject. Tread lightly with them.

What you are negotiating. You have made three promises to the public: leave the single market and customs union; no border between Great Britain and Northern Ireland; and no hard border between Northern Ireland and Ireland. You have taken a hard-Brexit approach, but you accept that a deal may not be feasible without some form of backstop.

Irish border and backstop. The border is the hardest file. You prefer no border at all, but accept a border may be unavoidable. The backstop is an insurance policy to keep the Irish border open whatever the outcome; in a no-deal scenario it would put the whole UK into a single customs territory with the EU, with Northern Ireland additionally aligned to some EU rules. Theresa May’s red line: no UK leader can accept different rules for different parts of the UK, because a backstop applying to Northern Ireland alone would create a customs and regulatory border in the Irish Sea. As leverage, you could hint at withholding funds from the confidence-and-supply arrangement with the DUP, but you need their support for any Brussels deal, so use this carefully.

Trade. You want out of the customs union and single market but still want a substantial free trade agreement. You favour a “seamless and frictionless” border policed largely by technology (cameras, automated number-plate recognition), plus waivers for small traders and farmers from customs, agricultural and food-safety checks. In return you would seek “regulatory equivalence” with the EU to avoid inspections. You dislike being bound to EU regulation; look for a way to minimise checks without accepting a hard border.

Security. You want an ambitious, legally binding future security partnership: rapid and secure data exchange, cross-border operational cooperation, and continued cooperation with EU law-enforcement agencies. Preserving cooperation between the PSNI and An Garda Síochána against organised crime, paramilitary activity, smuggling and cybercrime is a priority.

Options menu (for Round 2). Remain in the EU; Common Market 2.0 (Norway-style plus a customs union, requiring the backstop); EFTA/EEA (in the single market, out of the customs union); May’s deal (leave single market and customs union); no deal.

Sources.

- Springford, J. (2018) ‘Theresa May’s Irish Trilemma’, CER. <https://www.cer.eu/insights/theresa-mays-irish-trilemma>
- McCormack, J. (2018), BBC News. <https://www.bbc.com/news/uk-northern-ireland-politics-44397110>
- House of Commons Library (2019), CBP-8397. <https://commonslibrary.parliament.uk/research-briefings/cbp-8397/>
- Full Fact (2019), ‘The Irish backstop’. <https://fullfact.org/europe/irish-backstop/>

- Politico (2019), 'The UK's Brexit options explained'. <https://www.politico.eu/article/uks-brexit-options-explained/>
- Pérez-Solórzano Borragán, N. and Cini, M. (2022) 'Brexit', in *European Union Politics*.

Democratic Unionist Party (DUP)

Who you are. The DUP is a unionist, socially conservative party based in Northern Ireland. You are pro-Brexit and you consistently oppose any “special status” for Northern Ireland, because any divergence between Northern Ireland and Great Britain threatens the unity of the United Kingdom. Having entered a confidence-and-supply arrangement with the Conservatives, you keep a minority government in office, which is your leverage.

What you are negotiating. You want a clean break from the EU while keeping Northern Ireland fully aligned with the rest of the UK. You accept the need for favourable trade terms and stability, but you will not budge on safeguarding the Union.

Irish border and backstop. Theresa May has floated a backstop under which Northern Ireland would keep following some EU rules, with no time limit and no unilateral exit. You want the backstop removed from the deal entirely; fight for that. If forced, you will accept a time limit on it, but nothing that leaves Northern Ireland permanently treated differently from Great Britain.

Trade. You back leaving the customs union and single market. Proposals to keep Northern Ireland under EU trade rules (for example on agri-food) would make you a different entity from the rest of the UK, even if the aim is to avoid a border. Oppose any regulation that aligns Northern Ireland with the single market.

Security. The UK prioritises NATO over EU security cooperation, but you may support EU cooperation on cybersecurity and counter-terrorism where it benefits the UK, and you can trade this support for movement on your core concern, the Union. You support PSNI–Garda cooperation but reject any all-Ireland police force or PSNI accountability to another country.

Your leverage. You can threaten to abstain on budget votes and to withhold confidence-and-supply support. Your overriding aim in Round 1 is to bind the UK Government to a line that protects UK unity before it goes to the table with Brussels.

Sources.

- Al Jazeera (2019), ‘Northern Ireland’s DUP opposes UK government’s Brexit plan’.
<https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2019/10/17/northern-irelands-dup-opposes-uk-governments-brexit-plan>
- McCormack, J. (2018), BBC News. <https://www.bbc.com/news/uk-northern-ireland-46269685>
- McCormack, J. (2019), BBC News. <https://www.bbc.com/news/uk-northern-ireland-46903876>
- European Policy Centre (2020), ‘Strong together’.
https://www.epc.eu/content/PDF/2020/14_Strong_together.pdf

Irish Government

Who you are. You represent the Irish Government. As the only EU member state sharing a land border with the UK, a hard Brexit raises the prospect of a land border between the Republic and Northern Ireland, and with it the risk of a return to past violence. The DUP's growing influence over the UK Government after the recent snap election makes your task harder.

What you are negotiating. Key sectors of the Irish economy are heavily exposed to the UK's departure. As a smaller member state, you must ensure the EU's negotiating objectives take account of Ireland's special position, above all through effective transitional arrangements and continued single-market access for goods transiting the UK.

Irish border and backstop. No return to a hard border is a vital national interest. The Good Friday Agreement and the peace process, combined with shared EU and single-market membership, made the border effectively disappear; that gain must be protected. You want the EU to hold firm on this and to ensure the Good Friday Agreement is not damaged by withdrawal. You support the backstop (the Northern Ireland Protocol) as proposed.

Trade. You want the closest possible EU-UK trade relationship, as comprehensive and wide in scope as possible, while protecting key Irish sectors. You are especially concerned about agri-food and livestock exports and about food and fuel imports, which come disproportionately from the UK.

Security. The UK and Ireland cooperate closely on foreign policy and development within the EU's CFSP. You want the UK to remain closely associated with EU foreign, security and development policy after departure, and you regard continued cross-border policing cooperation involving An Garda Síochána and the PSNI as very important.

Your role in Round 1. Press the Commission to make no hard border and the protection of the Good Friday Agreement non-negotiable, and to carry Ireland's specific economic concerns into the EU's common position.

Sources.

- Department of the Taoiseach, Brexit report. https://merrionstreet.ie/merrionstreet/en/eu-uk/key_irish_documents/m10016_department_of_the_taoiseach_brexit_report_web_spreads-2_new_pdf.pdf
- Government approach to the Brexit negotiations. https://merrionstreet.ie/en/eu-uk/key_irish_documents/government_approach_to_brexit_negotiations.pdf

European Commission

Who you are. You are the European Commission, negotiating the Withdrawal Agreement on behalf of the member states after the UK's Article 50 notification. The EU Chief Negotiator is Michel Barnier, supported by the Article 50 Taskforce. You hold the stronger hand: the EU27 maintain a unified voice, and the UK seems less prepared for that.

What you are negotiating. Following the European Council's negotiating guidelines, you act with one voice and commit to transparency. Your fixed principles: a non-member cannot enjoy the same rights and benefits as a member; the integrity of the single market must be preserved; and the Good Friday Agreement and peace in Northern Ireland must be upheld. "Nothing is agreed until everything is agreed."

Irish border and backstop. You want a framework that fully respects the Good Friday Agreement and avoids a hard border (no physical infrastructure, checks or controls). Because the UK will leave the single market, you are concerned about the vagueness of the UK's technological proposals. Your preferred solution is a backstop written into the Withdrawal Agreement, keeping Northern Ireland aligned with single-market and customs-union rules; you also want assurances on continued free movement for those in Northern Ireland who remain Irish (and therefore EU) citizens, under the Common Travel Area. Listen to Ireland and reassure it on the peace process.

Trade. You seek a close economic relationship, potentially a free trade agreement, that minimises friction while guaranteeing the UK upholds standards on the environment and labour and does not compete unfairly (a level playing field). You propose a "common regulatory area" on the island of Ireland covering goods, agriculture, fisheries, the Single Electricity Market and state aid. Take account of Ireland's specific requests and fold them into the EU position.

Security. You want close cooperation on law enforcement and information-sharing (for example the European Arrest Warrant and Europol), coordinated responses to security and cyber threats, and external-border security against illegal migration and smuggling, including the terms of any UK involvement with Frontex. Note that the UK will lose access to the Schengen Information System. Consider Ireland's specific concerns.

Options menu (for Round 2). Remaining in the Union; European Economic Area (accept the four freedoms and EU rules without a vote); Swiss option (tariff-free goods access, no services deal); free trade agreement (preferential access, firms still meet EU standards); no deal (UK free on future deals but far weaker at the table).

Sources.

- Carswell, S. (2019), *The Irish Times*. <https://www.irishtimes.com/news/politics/brexit-explained-why-does-the-border-matter-and-what-is-the-backstop-1.3661518>
- European Movement (2023), 'The future of EU-UK cooperation on security and defence'. <https://europeanmovement.eu/policy/the-future-of-eu-uk-cooperation-on-security-and-defence/>
- European Commission Representation in Ireland (2023), 'The impact of Brexit on Ireland'. https://ireland.representation.ec.europa.eu/strategy-and-priorities/key-eu-policies-ireland/impact-brexit-ireland_en

- European Council, 'The EU's response to Brexit'. <https://www.consilium.europa.eu>